

Ali Kozehgaran

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EDUCATION

Ph.D., Quantitative Marketing 2021 — 2027 (Expected)
Syracuse University

Committee: Scott Fay (Chair), S.P Raj, Candace Jens, Liangbin Yang, Minjung Kwon

M.Sc., Industrial Engineering 2018 — 2020
Sharif University of Technology

B.Sc., Industrial Engineering 2014 — 2018
Shiraz University of Technology

RESEARCH INTERESTS & METHODS

Substantive: Platform Economics, Information Asymmetry, Digital Transformation, Services Marketing, Mechanism Design, Marketing Strategy

Methods: Empirical Modeling, Causal Inference, Machine Learning, Big Data, Generative AI

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE (* INDICATES DISSERTATION ESSAY)

Data

- Airbnb Listings Data — Independently negotiated and acquired proprietary Airbnb market data; fully owned, available for use in current and future research projects.

Publications

- Fay, S., Kozehgaran, A. (2026). “Learning from Service Experience Ratings: Effects on Experience Quality, Credence Quality, and Customer Satisfaction” *Journal of Retailing*, 102(2), 353–370. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretai.2025.12.005>

Working Papers

- * “When Does Visual Manipulation Work? Evidence from Online Marketplaces” [Draft]
Kozehgaran, Ali, Yang, Liangbin, Jiang, Juncai
Under review at the *Journal of Production and Operations Management (POM)*
- “Using Leasing Intensity to Signal Product Longevity” [Abstract]
Fay, Scott A., Kozehgaran, Ali,
Under review at the *Journal of Quantitative Marketing and Economics (QME)*
- * “Disintermediation and Coalition Formation in The Traditional Taxi Industry” [Abstract]
Kozehgaran, Ali, Fay, Scott A., Kwon, Minjung
Preparing for submission to the *Journal of Marketing Research*

Work in Progress

- “POI Spillovers and Spatial Competition in the Short-Term Rental Market”
(with J. Jiang and L. Yang) — **Winner of 2025 Dewey Data Research Grant**
- “Beyond the First Impression: A Two-Stage Framework for Consumer Decisions on Digital Platforms” (with L. Yang, S. Fay)
- “Recreational Marijuana Legalization and Short-Term Rentals” (with J. Jiang and L. Yang)

CONFERENCES & WORKSHOPS

Presentations:

- “When Does Visual Manipulation Work? Evidence from Online Marketplaces”
Previously titled: “Visual Deception or Enhancement? The Impact of Image Manipulation on Shaping Consumer Perceptions”
 - Platform Strategy Research Symposium, Boston University Jul 2026
 - AI/ML/BA Conference, Columbia Business School Dec 2025
 - Marketing Science Conference (ISMS) Jun 2025
- “Disintermediation and Coalition Formation in Traditional Taxi Industry”
Previously titled: “Effect of a Paradigm Shift on Traditional Taxi Drivers”
 - MarkTech Conference, Columbia Business School Dec 2024
 - PDMA Doctoral Consortium Aug 2024
 - Syracuse University, LPP255 - Introduction to the Legal System (Invited talk) Mar 2024
 - Association of Marketing Theory & Practice (AMTP) Mar 2023
- “Optimizing Personalized Commissions in Taxi Platforms: A Data-Driven Approach”
 - Marketing Science Conference (ISMS) Jun 2022

Workshops:

- Hands-On AI/ML in Research - Syracuse University (presenter) Apr 2024
- Frontiers in Difference-in-Differences Oct 2023
- Research Design for Causal Inference (Northwestern) Aug 2023

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor of Record:

[Teaching Methods & Strategies]

- **Brand Management** Fall 2026 (scheduled)
 - 60 students ◦ Two sections
 - Simulation-based ◦ Advanced undergraduate elective
- **Essentials of Marketing** Spring 2025
 - 30 students ◦ Non-business majors (Required for marketing minors)
- **Principles of Marketing** Spring 2024
 - 42 students ◦ Business majors (Undergraduate core course)

Guest Lecturer:

- Doctoral Seminar in Marketing | Topic: Platform Economics & Causal Inference Fall 2025
- Data-Driven Decision-Making Analysis | Topic: Tools and Methods Spring 2020

Teaching Assistant:

- Operation Research Spring 2019-20
- Advanced Game Theory Spring 2019

ACADEMIC AWARDS, GRANTS & HONORS

- **Doctoral Student Teacher Scholar Award** | Marketing Management Association 2026
- **Doctoral Consortium Fellow** | Platform Strategy Symposium, Boston University 2026
- **Research Grant** | Whitman School of Management 2022-26
- **Research Grant** | Winner of Dewey Data Research Grant 2025

- **Doctoral Consortium Fellow** | ISMS, Terry College of Business 2025
- **Doctoral Consortium Fellow** | PDMA, Whitman School of Business 2024
- **Doctoral Consortium Fellow** | ISMS, Chicago Booth School of Business 2022
- **Ranked 1st** | National University Entrance Exam, Industrial Engineering (M.Sc.) 2018
 - Out of +10,000 participants
- **Ranked 10th** | National Scientific Olympiad - Industrial Engineering 2018
- **Scholarships:**
 - Top Student of the Year by Pazhohesh Institute (\$2,000) 2018
 - Tuition Waiver Scholarship at Sharif University of Technology 2018-2020
 - Tuition Waiver Scholarship at Shiraz University of Technology 2014-2018

PROFESSIONAL SERVICES

- Conference Co-Organizer** | PDMA Doctoral Consortium 2024
- Vice President** | Iranian Students Association (ISA) 2023-24
- President** | Industrial Engineering Scientific Association 2016-17

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Python, R, Stata, HPC (*Cluster-computing*), Mathematica

SELECTED COURSEWORK

Syracuse University:

Panel Data, Econometrics (I,II,III), Big Data Analytics, Advanced Regression Modeling Methods, Doctoral Seminar in Marketing (I,II,III,IV), Microeconomics

Sharif University of Technology:

Advanced Regression Analysis, Time-Series Analysis, Data-Driven Decision Making, Game Theory

LIST OF REFERENCES

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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Scott Fay (Advisor)
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Associate Professor of Finance
Syracuse University |

Selected Research Abstracts

- ***“When Does Visual Manipulation Work? Evidence from Online Marketplaces”***
Ali Kozezhgaran, Liangbin Yang, Juncal Jiang

Visual manipulation is increasingly prevalent in digital marketplaces, yet its impact on market outcomes remains largely undocumented. We study this question using a unique longitudinal panel of 33,000 Airbnb properties in California, where hosts may manipulate listing images to influence consumer evaluation. Employing a state-of-the-art forensic detection framework that detects both AI-based and Photoshop-based visual manipulation, we estimate the effect of manipulation on property revenue using a matrix completion approach to construct counterfactual outcomes. The results reveal substantial heterogeneity across manipulation technologies. AI manipulation increases monthly revenue by 14.3% (approximately \$650), whereas Photoshop editing has no measurable effect. Furthermore, effects are strongest when alternative information signals (e.g., Superhost badge or guest reviews) are limited, when images convey richer information (e.g., high-amenity and entire-property listings), and when manipulation is applied at moderate levels and targets amenity-related focal elements. Overall, our findings show that visual manipulation can meaningfully enhance marketplace performance, but only under specific technological and contextual conditions. These results offer actionable guidance for platforms governing visual content and for firms calibrating visual manipulation strategies in digital environments.

- ***“Disintermediation and Coalition Formation in Traditional Taxi Industry”***
Ali Kozezhgaran, Scott Fay, Minjung Kwon

This study examines the causal impact of mobile hailing technology adoption and coalition-based network integration on traditional taxi drivers’ performance and efficiency in a mixed-supply transportation model. Using panel data of +50 million trips from over 5,800 drivers across six years in Chicago, we apply an interactive fixed effects (IFE) estimator to account for latent heterogeneity and staggered adoption, and validate our findings using the Callaway and Sant’Anna (2021) difference-in-differences framework. Our results show that platform adoption significantly increases driver performance—raising income, trips, and total working time—but these gains are primarily driven by greater labor input rather than improvements in operational efficiency. Critically, we find that affiliation with a network of platform partners (i.e., a coalition) does not, on its own, amplify the benefits of adoption. The largest and most sustained performance and efficiency gains emerge only when coalition membership is paired with high usage intensity. These findings point to a behavioral complementarity: the value of technology is contingent not just on adoption, but on sustained engagement within a structured, trusted network. Our analysis reveals that partial adoption or overreliance on platform-based dispatching can undermine spatial efficiency, while integrated users—those who are both network-affiliated and high-usage—are better positioned to mitigate these inefficiencies. These insights align with recent observations from other sectors, such as AI adoption, where lack of organizational integration and usage behavior often limits efficiency gains. By combining robust causal inference with a detailed behavioral and structural analysis, this study provides novel insight into the role of coalition design in enabling effective platform transformation. The findings offer practical guidance for platform managers, policymakers, and service providers seeking to foster sustainable innovation in traditional service markets.

- ***“Using Leasing Intensity to Signal Product Longevity”***

Scott A. Fay, Ali Kozehgaran

Consumers’ willingness-to-pay for a durable good depends upon its perceived longevity, i.e., the duration for which the product continues to function properly. However, because consumers cannot observe longevity prior to purchase, it is difficult for manufacturers to capitalize on investments that enhance product longevity. In this paper, we demonstrate that the leasing market can provide a credible mechanism for signaling product longevity. In our analytical model, a manufacturer both leases and sells a durable good. Leased units are returned to the manufacturer after the lease period ends and then leased again in the secondary market as long as they continue to be functional. When consumers cannot observe longevity, a separating equilibrium arises in which a manufacturer signals high longevity by reducing the lease price and allocating a disproportionate share of production to the leasing market (i.e., uses a high “leasing intensity”). Consumers benefit from this credible signaling because lessees now incur lower usage costs and buyers now avoid overpaying for products with low longevity. In fact, consumers, on average, are better off in the signaling equilibrium than if longevity were directly observable. Our finding that signaling enhances manufacturers’ incentives to invest in product longevity suggests this could be an important mechanism for promoting sustainability initiatives.